



Learning from the best: Ishika Chaudhary will feature for the Odisha Warriors, along with FIH women's Player of the Year and Netherlands' Olympic gold medallist Yibbi Jansen.

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"It's a new phase, I would say," says defender Ishika Chaudhary of Odisha Warriors. "The timing is impeccable in the sense that the very moment women's hockey saw a dip (Paris 2024 non-selection), HIL decided to come along and give us hope. We'll get the experience of playing with foreign players who have good experience of featuring in the Olympics. We get a look into the mentality of those who have been world champions. It wasn't so good for us when we didn't qualify."

Ishika will be learning from the best when she teams up with the FIH women's Player of the Year and Netherlands' Olympic gold medallist Yibbi Jansen come January, like Amit did in 2013. "They were all big players. Double Olympic winners like Moritz Furste of Germany were in my team. I learnt a lot about playing as a defender from them. They taught

you about positioning, tackling and passing. Even if you were making mistakes, they wouldn't scold you. They used to cover for our mistakes and help push the level of the team high by instilling confidence," remembers Amit.

The auction dynamics in 2024 also hint at India's overbearing presence on the global map of hockey. In the 2013 auction, the marquee set was dominated by overseas players, with three foreigners earning more than Sandeep Singh and Sardar Singh. This time around, the top three bids in the men's auction have all gone to Indians.

In 2016, then-18-year-old midfielder Hardik was

picked up by Jaypee Punjab Warriors for over ₹33 lakh. In 2024, he commanded a price of ₹70 lakh — the third-most expensive bid in the auction.

Manpreet (**below**), who signed for Team Gonasika for ₹42 lakh, feels, "Franchises have seen the success that the Indian team has had in recent years and have decided to invest in whichever good Indian players are there. All the experienced and even young players have got good money this time. Before, there was a lot of dependency on foreign players, but this time, they have decided to bank on Indian players."

In the women's auction too, four of the top five went to Indians, with defender Udita (**facing page, below**) coming out on top with ₹32 lakh. Udita feels that the platform, which will attract plenty of eyeballs, is a good start for the women's game. "More often than not, we tend to focus on the national teams. Other players get sidelined automatically. During the Nationals, as a lot of international players feature, much of the focus is on them, and we don't take a look at the up-and-coming talent who will shape the future of the sport in the country," she says. It

was mandated by the HIL organising committee that four of the 24 players in a squad needed to be juniors.

Salima Tete will be part of the Soorma Hockey Club, one of the four women's teams, as

opposed to the eight-team league in the men's competition. The midfielder is hopeful that the addition of more teams in the next edition will increase the competitive level of the league. "We are only a four-team league now, and by the next edition,



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